MUSICAL

Here We GO *Again*

MAMMA MIA!, the popular musical from London's West End and one of the world's longest running, is being performed live in Mumbai currently



Mumbai is accustomed to the razzle-dazzle of Bollywood. Even so, the attendees at the premiere of *MAMMA MIA!*, the romantic musical that's making a longish stop on its international tour, watched in thrall throughout the show and were up on their feet, clapping and dancing to the catchy numbers for the encore at the end.

MAMMA MIA! has won the hearts of millions since it was first performed live in 1999. It's a tale that has since been relished by over 65 million people worldwide in 50 productions in 16 different languages. The show that has wowed London's West End and has travelled to several countries for the last 25 years, has now arrived in India. *MAMMA MIA!* will be performed every evening at the 2,000-seater Grand Theatre at Mumbai's Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) until January 7, 2024. With over 22 hit songs by the 1970s Swedish pop group ABBA, 181 costume changes, and a story that shines a light on various relationships played by 30 actors, plus seven members of the live band, it's a musical extravaganza calculated to charm.

Speaking of charm, for a decade now, Sara Poyzer has brought grace and gravitas to the role of Donna Sheridan, mother of Sophie, the bride-to-be, and the one whose romantic adventures two decades ago are now resulting in three men being invited to the wedding as possible fathers of the bride! The ensuing shenanigans and soul-searching are what keep the audience glued to their seats and hanging on every word (and note) that the cast performs.

Meryl Streep had made this character her own in the film version, which most people have watched. We asked Poyzer how she interprets the body language and expressions for the stage performance. "I think that truth is always key. I don't like to analyse my own performance too much, I tend to rely on the techniques I have learnt over the years. When I first played the role of Donna, the film had yet to be released, so I didn't have the pressure of playing the Meryl Streep role straight away. But now it feels like a privilege to walk in the same shoes as someone as extraordinary as Meryl," says Poyzer, adding with a twinkle, "That said, I'd be lying if I said I hadn't stolen some of the traits that Meryl brought to the role!"

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Meanwhile, when asked to describe the details that go into taking such a larger-than-life spectacle on tour, associate producer Nick Grace explains, "We travel